

HARI CHANDANA DASARI, 42
Secretary, SHAKTI Department, Telangana
Hyderabad

Problem Solver

A 2010-batch IAS officer of the Telangana cadre, Hari Chandana recalls an incident from her 2020-2023 tenure as district collector of Narayanpet that, she says, captures the essence of public service. She was visiting the weekly market when a woman approached her to say that the newly introduced eco-friendly mobile She-toilet had allowed her to return to selling produce. Until then, the lack of a place to relieve herself through the long market day had forced her to stay away, costing her a vital source of income. "Her one sentence taught me more about what governance is for than any file ever has," Hari Chandana says.

WOMAN TO WOMAN

"Women are conditioned to believe we must be fully qualified, certain and prepared before we step forward, while the world doesn't ask the same of others. I have taken on every meaningful role in my career before I felt entirely ready for it, and the readiness came through the doing"

That focus on solving everyday problems and making governance more accessible and inclusive has come to define her 16-year career. Since taking charge of Telangana's Labour, Employment, Training and Factories Department in April 2026, she has overseen its transformation into SHAKTI—Skill, Human Capital and Knowledge Training Initiatives. Beyond the rebranding, she has driven the state's first comprehensive minimum wage revision, a reform recognised by the International Labour Organization and one that is expected to benefit over 9.2 million workers. She is also developing an integrated skilling framework and shaping welfare measures for more than 400,000 gig and platform workers.

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

Over 16 years in the IAS, Hari Chandana has transformed everyday civic challenges into enduring public solutions, most recently spearheading Telangana's minimum wage reform benefiting 9.2 million workers

Public service is a family tradition. The daughter of a former IAS officer and married to an IRS officer, Hari Chandana combines that grounding with academic training in environmental economics and political science from the London School of Economics and the University of Hyderabad. Before her current posting, she was Hyderabad district collector for a year. In that time, she introduced WhatsApp Prajavani, enabling senior citizens and persons with disabilities to register grievances remotely; launched Project Shakti, providing reusable sanitary pad kits to 60,000 schoolgirls; and set up the Samatha Canteen, staffed by transgender persons and people with disabilities, at the collectorate office. Earlier, in Nalgonda, she had helped rural women convert invasive water hyacinth into sustainable products. With each successive posting, her canvas has only grown larger. ■

—Prasad Nichenametla